

Mata o Muna 3

Te Āhiga: Te Loto o te Fenua

I te gāloto o te fenua o Nanumea, e tu i ai tona āhiga. I matala o te āhiga ko feitu e lua ko Haumeafa mo Lolua, mo olou falefoliki e fafogā mo galuega mo lukuga o te fenua. Te feitu ki te namo ko te faletapu, te fale o te faifeau mo fale ake o te lotu. Te āhiga ko te fakaaūtūga o meafai faka te fenua. I taimi katoa e luku ai tino Nanumea ki he mea e kau katoa i ai te fenua, a latou e luku ki konei i te āhiga. Te mata o muna tenei e fakamatala i te āhiga mo ona tala fakaholo fakatahi, mo tona tāua i pō nei me ni mo mea e luku ai te fenua mo te iloga tafahili i te tāua o Nanumea me he fenua.

Te Āhiga Nāteaho Mua Loa

E hē iloa tonu me nāfea ni faite ai te āhiga muamua o Nanumea. Kae me ko fale e luku ai tino e maua i fenua uke o Polinisia pelā hoki mo te fenua pili mai ko Kilipati mo fenua ake o Maikolonisia, ko mafai ai o fai e tātou me i te āhiga ko te faka autūga o te ola o te fenua i Nanumea mai taimi mua loa. Te tuku taumatega tenei e lāgo malo e tala fai gutu mai mua kolā e tala mai me i mea nāteaho ni tupu i te āhiga. Te fakamainaga e tahi ko te tala ia taitai mo Temotu (Kaitu mo Uakeia) telā ni tā i ai a Taitai i te luaniga ki te huiga o te pou e tahi o te āhiga. E tonu ailoa me i te āhiga ni kāmata o fakavae i te fia o senitenali ko olo, hē motuhia i tona tulaga ailoa nei i te gāloto o te fa'kai.

Te āhiga mua ni faite ki mea katoa fakatātou. I ona pou ni fala e tu iluga i muli pou milo me e tai fui pala. A oka mo tua fala ni fala fafai. Ko pou lagalago a tua mo ona pelesese ni kauniu koa oti hoki ni fafai, ko pou tafae noho ki te 4 iniisi ki te 2 iniisi, mo talava ko te 3 ki te 2 iniisi. Te fola o te āhiga pelā mo te hauga mua, e fai ki kilikili, kae fakamuli koa fai ki lahe mo sameni, ko 'haga mo utupoto e fau katoa ki kafa. Te tuafale e ato ki lau mo ona feitu e pui mai te matagi mo te ua e tīpola kolā ni pui e laga ki launiu pakupaku (e 4 futu ki te 1 futu te lahi). E hēai ni mea i lotu i te fale ko te fola kapau ake ailoa e fetu koa tukukuk ai fakatahi ki te matakikioga o te āhiga. I taimi e luku ai te fenua ki te āhiga, e tahi hau ailoa te kāiga mo olotou papa noho o fola mai luga ki kapau o te āhiga.

Chapter 3

The Āhiga: The Heart of the Community

At the center of the village in Nanumea stands the island's community hall, its āhiga. On either end of the building are the two small structures. These are owned by each village side (feitu), Lolua and Haumeafa, and are used for their meetings and work parties. Toward the lagoon is the community playing field, malae, and to the ocean side is the church, the pastor's house and other church buildings. The āhiga is the focus of all island-wide activities. Whenever Nanumeans meet for an event involving the whole community, te fenua, they gather here. This chapter describes the āhiga and its history, along with its importance today as a gathering place and as the core symbol of Nanumea as a community.

The Ancient Āhiga

We cannot be sure when the first of Nanumea's āhiga was built. But since the meeting house institution is found in so many societies of Polynesia, as well as neighboring Kiribati and other Micronesian societies, we can conclude that the āhiga has probably been the focus for community life in Nanumean since the earliest times. This conclusion is also supported by traditional stories which tell about ancient events that happened in the āhiga. An example is the story of Taitai and Temotu (their other names are Kaitu and Uakeia), in which Taitai was killed while helping replace one of the pillars of the āhiga. Certainly, the āhiga was established in Nanumea many centuries ago, most likely in its present location at the heart of the village.

The ancient āhiga was built completely of local materials. Its main pillars were made of fala which were supported by base posts made of milo, which was slow to rot. The rafters and roof structure were made of split fala timbers. The external supporting posts and cross pieces were made of coconut timber which had also been split, the outer posts about 4x2 inches and tālava crosspieces about 3x2 inches. The floor of the āhiga was originally made of kilikili gravel, and later of lime cement, while the beams and cross beams were all lashed with braided coconut fiber cord. The roof was thatched with pandanus and the sides were protected from wind and rain by tīpola shades woven from dried coconut fronds (tīpola were about 4 ft by 1 ft in size). There was nothing inside the building except a flooring of rough kapau mats, which normally were folded up and gathered together in the corner of the building. When the community gathered in the building, each family

Atu lā te vaega o te āhiga mua tafahili i te fakaofoofogina ki te mafaufau ko tona tua fale lau telā e manakogina he fia afe o lau ni fai limagina. Te tuafale mauluga e mafai o lavea mai mo mea katoa i loto i te fa'kai. Ko lātou kolā e noho i loto e olotou lavea a selau o unu lau koa oti ni ato fakalei, ko kāiga takitahi e noho i olotou inaki, momea fakatino tonu mō latou i loto i te āhiga. Te tuafale tenei e galue 'lei 'kī ki te 'pui o latou kolā i loto mai te lā, matagi mo te ua, ka ko te mea e lahi te taimi fakamaumau mo te fakatumauga tona lei. E noho ki te tolu tauhaga e toe liaki ai te lau. Te mea nei he haga lahi o te fenua ko kāiga katoa e fai tau tino lau mo kolokolo. E mafai o tuku ki fafine takitokotahi e taki kautelau lau olotou tautino ka ake e manakogina mōte fakafouga o te āhiga. Te galuega a tamatāne ko te atoga o lau o te āhiga, mo tamāfine e tali lau ka ko tamatāne e kake i oka o fakamaoe tonu a lau koa ato ai pelā mo te fakatonuga a taumatua.

Fakafouga o Te Āhiga

Te āhiga i pō nei koa heke, ko faite ki mea palagi katoa. E tu i te tūgafale o te āhiga mua (fakavae mua) kae e tai lahi atu, pelā mo 30 ki te 50 mita te lahi. Te toe fakatūga ki kamata i te 1964 kae ni fakaoti i te 1965, mo te galuega ni fai katoa e tino o te fenua. Te faifeau ko Enoka Alesana (mai Samoa) mo te faifeau ko Founuku Tipelu (mai Nanumea) ni fesoasoani hoki ki ai. Mua e mafai o noho he tino o pula ki luga i kauafe o lau e fai ki ai te tuafale, a mea nei koa oti katoa ni hui ki kapa mo te fālo koa oti hoki ni fakapiki. Telā lā, a loto o te fale koa tai maualalo i lō te nohoga mua. Te heke hoki ki te faiga o te fola telā koa fai ki sameni o hui te kilikili koa hā fakaaogā. A kapau e māhani o fakaaogā mua, mo fakamalu te fola kilikili, nei koa hē fakaaogā, ka ko papa koi tōmau te fola mo noho iluga i te fola sameni maniania.

Te āhiga tenei e fakafou ona mea mahei kae toe penifou i taki 10 tauhaga, me fanatu hoki. Te toe fakafouga o mea mahei fakamuli nei ailoa ni tai noho ki he mahina te leva tēlāni fakaoti i pō utua o Setema i te 2002. O kapa o tuafale ni hui i te taimi nei, mo te fālo fou malapulapu e piki i ai moli iti kolā 'loa ni fakapiki. Ni fakapiki hoki a pelūga pola kanivesi fou, mo pui maualalo o faitu o te fale ni toe hui ka ko noho ifo ki he maluga telā e gali i te 'pula ki tahaoga i tafa i te malae. Te laupapa iloto e tuai muna "United We Stand" (Kaufakatahi e Tōmau ai Tātou) e tala ki Haumeafa, mo "N'ameana II" e tala ki Lolua. Ni toe peni mo fale fakatoka kae tauti i ai meakai ni faite i tala ote āhiga fakatau mo faitu e lua. Te fale o Haumeafa e fakaioga kia "Faikimua" ko ko te fale o Lolua ko "Faivalevale II." Te āhiga fou mo tona peni

brought its own sitting mats to place on top of the rough undermats.

Probably the most impressive feature of the ancient āhiga was its thatched roof, which required many thousands of hand-made pandanus thatch panels. The high roof would have been visible from anywhere in the village center. Those seated inside would have seen the hundreds of rows of neatly tied thatch, and each family would have sat under a particular roof section, their inaki. This roof worked wonderfully to shield those inside from the sun, wind and rain, but was time-consuming to maintain. About every three years, the thatch needed renewing. This was a major village project and all families would be assigned to provide an amount of thatch and rolled sennit cord. Each woman might be assigned to make one hundred thatch panels for her contribution, while men would have to supply a set number of fathoms of cord as well as other building materials needed for the renovation. The young people had the job of thatching the āhiga, with young women carrying the thatch panels and the young men climbing up in the rafters to position and tie them under the direction of elders.

Modernizing the Āhiga

Today's āhiga, by contrast, is made entirely of permanent materials. It stands on the site of the ancient foundation, though it is a bit larger, at 30 by 50 meters. The reconstruction was begun in 1964 and completed in 1965, with all labor supplied the people. Pastors Enoka Alesana (from Samoa) and the Reverend Founuku Tipelu (from Nanumea) also gave their support. While before, one could sit and look up to the thousands of thatch panels making up the roof, these were now replaced with metal, and a ceiling was installed, so the interior of the building felt much lower than previously. Also different was the flooring, which was now made of cement instead of gravel. Woven coconut leaf rough mats (which cushioned the gravel floor) are no longer used, though sitting mats, papa, are still spread as seating over the smooth cement floor.

Every decade or so this building is also renovated and repainted. The most recent renovation (at the time of this writing, in 2004), lasted nearly a month and was completed in late September 2002. The roofing metal was replaced at this time, and a new shiny ceiling with fluorescent lighting was installed. New drop-down rolls of canvas tarps (yellow inside, green outside) were also installed, and the low walls of the building were replaced and lowered to an ideal height for sitting and watching play in the playing field. The interior signs "United We Stand" (Haumeafa end) and "N'ameana II" (Lolua end) were repainted and large new food preparation and auxiliary storage buildings were built at each end of the hall for the two sides. Haumeafa's building is called "Faikimua," and Lolua's is "Faivalevale." With its fresh white interior paint with light green accents,

tea fou mo te unoko māmā ni mo mea 'fago mafaufau mō meafai a te fenua.

Muna a tino me i pō mua loa a te āhiga ko te āhiga ailoa, e heai hona igoa fakapatino. I te taimi muamua ailoa ni fakatū ai te āhiga ki mea palagai i te 1964, ni mafaufau ai taumatua ke fai he igoa mō te fale. E uke a igoa ni mafaufaugina kae ni manatu latou ke fakaaogā te fuaiupu "Ni a au mea na?" Ni fakavae ki ai te igoa faka-fatuga kupu "N'ameana." Te igoa tenei e fakatu ki te ahi me fakaali a mea tāua kolā e fai i loto i te āhiga i te taimi e fakaali ai e taumatua olotou muna, manatu mo olotou uiga fai i lāuga (e fakaali a mea e noho mo latou) mo taimi kolā e fakahao ai a meakai ni fakatoka e kāiga ni fakatino ke fai te vaega fakamuli tenei e olo ni tino o ahi āiga takitahi i meakai i olotou kete mo telē me ko ai tino e lātoa mo tino e hē katoa mo te manakoga. Muna a tino me i te faifeau ko Enaoka Alesana ni fesoasoani i te faiga tenei telā ni hau mo ia te igoa telā ni peni o fakatautau i te āhiga, i te taimi o te fakatuga o te āhiga ki mea 'palagi.

I pō mua, i taimi e fai i ai ni meafai i pō i fale me i te āhiga, te fakamainaga e fai ki mōlī fagogo kolā e faka ki hinu mo hinu tafolā (manafai e i ai) telā i ni taimi e maua. Te 'vae e faka ki te afi e maua i te hika. I te mahina-hulu koa lava ailoa i ai tona mainaga i meafai i te āhiga. Ni kāmata i te 1940 ke oko ki te 1950 o fakaaogā a mōlī fagu mo mōlī matagi. Ni maua fagu pumatāefa i te 'nohoga a sotia/kautau Amelika i Nanumea i te Taua i te Lua o te Lalolagi. Mai mōlī fagu konei, mo te 'vae tautau i te gāloto mo mō kalsini i te muli ni faite mōlī fagu a tino Nanumea. Telā tona uiga a fale katoa koa tofu mo mōlī taumāmā. Mōlī kalasini katoa i te vaega penei ko aumai e lātou he mainaga tai 'lei atu ki te āhiga mō mea fai a te fenua i lō o mōlī fagogo mua.

I loto i te 10 tauhaga o te 1960, te fakaaogāgaga o te kasa koa hē fou. Ko āvaga a tāgata Nanumea kolā e 'galue i te mālō i Talava ni 'togi e lātou te masini iti telā ni fakaaogā mō fakamaina te āhiga, te faletapu mo te fale o te faifeau. Hē leva mai tua ifo, ite 1980 mo te 1990 te taulahiga o kāiga ni 'togi mōlī lā mo te fesoasoani mai te mālō lahi mo te polotieki fesoasoani mai tua atu o Tuvalu. I te senitenali fou, mai te 2000 (fakatau) fano ki mua te iti no oko ki fale katoa o te fa'kai mo fale o te fenua mai masisi ni kolā i te fale masini o te kamupane iti i Funafuti, telā koa tu pili ki te tātuga. E maua te iti i te togi (faka kātōa) kae i te 2004 gālue i te 14-18 itula i te aso.

Te Fale o Muna

Te muna "āhiga" ko te nauna ni maua, e talitonu e mātou, mai te veape "āhi" telā e uke ana uiga, pelā mo uiga konei, "akili," "fakataufai," "tofo," "pula ki ai,"

the renewed āhiga is an impressive place for island activities.

People say that in ancient times the āhiga was simply the āhiga, it had no special name. At the time of the first reconstruction of the building in permanent materials about 1964, elders decided to name the building. Many names were considered, and they decided to use the phrase "What have you got?" Ni ā au Mea Nā as the basis for the poetic name "N'ameana." This name refers to the important activity of āhi or display, which takes place in the āhiga when elders display their words, thoughts and character in speeches (showing what they've got), and also when the prescribed foods that families have prepared are evaluated. In this latter case, several people āhi around the hall, stopping by each family, examine their food trays and kete, and announce to the hall whether one meets, or fails to meet, the requirement. People say that the pastor at the time of the reconstruction, Enoka Alesana, helped in this process of coming up with a name by painting a sign to hang in the āhiga.

In the old days, when there were events after dark in homes or the āhiga, lighting was provided by coconut shell lamps (mōlī fāgogo) which burned coconut oil or whale oil, which was sometimes available. The wick was lit with fire produced by a fire plow method (hika). At full moon, moonlight also sufficed for āhiga activities. Starting in the 1940s and into the 1950s, the bottle lamp (mōlī fagu) and a few hurricane lamps (mōlī matagi) were introduced. Wide-mouth glass jars became available from the American troops stationed at Nanumea during World War II. From these bottles, with a wick hung in the middle and a bit of kerosene in the bottom, Nanumeans made "bottle lamps" (mōlī fagu), which meant all houses could now have inexpensive lamps. Kerosene lamps of all these types provided better light in the āhiga for community events than was possible with the old coconut oil lamps.

In the decade of the 1960s, the use of pressure lamps was common. Wives of Nanumean men who worked for the government in Tarawa purchased a generator which was used to light the āhiga, the church and the pastor's house. Not long after this, in the 1980 and 1990's, solar lights were purchased by the majority of families, with support from the central government and an overseas aid project. In the new century, from about 2000 onward, electric power has been provided to all village houses and public buildings by a diesel generator in a powerhouse near the cemetery, owned by the electricity authority in Funafuti. Power is available at a subsidized rate, and in 2004 was provided for 14-18 hours per day.

The House of Words

The term āhiga is a noun we believe to be derived from the verb "āhi," which has various meanings including "to visit, check up on, inspect, display,

"fakaali," kae pelā hoki "āhi," olo o hepaki mo tino i 'lou fale. Hē motuhia ko uiga tafahili i te aogā ko lāua i konei e lua, ko "fakaali," mo "pula ki ai (āhi)." I kaiga e fai i uta i te āhiga a pule o te fenua e māhani o fai ke āhi ki kāiga katoa o pula ki olotou mea kai, fakaluaga. Ni lua tino e olo o āhi ki kāiga, kae e tapatapa (e 'tau o fai ke fakakatakata tino) me koa i ai me koa hē ai a meakai konā. Te uiga aogā e tahi o te muna "āhi" ko fakaali.

Mea kolā e fakaali ko muna, manatu, iloga, kae apo o taumatua o kāiga takitahi, ko tāgata kolā e tavili i te fale. Te fakamunaga, "te fale o muna," e pelā me e 'tau mo te āhiga o Nanumea, me ko te "Āhiga o Muna o te Fale." Te Fale o Muna, ko te fale telā e tausi i ai a kopekopega mo koloa 'tāua o te fenua, e hē ko mea e lavea ki mata, kae ko muna tuku mai a lātou kolā koa 'galo atu, konei e tūmau a te fāgai ki ai a kautama gāholo o te fenua i loto i te fale tenei, ko te Fale o Muna. Te fakamunaga "Āhiga o Muna," koa oti lā a tino ni fāgai kae fāinu ki muna o te fale, a te mea e tafa mai nei ko te "Āhiga o muna o te Fale" ko te taimi koa 'tofo i ai a te fakalogo mo te puke ki "Muna o te Fale, e mata ni puke koe ki ai, me mata e puke nei koe ki ai, me mata koa puke koe ki ai mai mua nei.

A muna konei, kolā e fakaali te mahala mo akoakoga mo kautama mai mua atu o Nanumea, ko he vaega tafahili i te tāua o te maumea o te fenua. I loto o lāuga e māhani o fai i te fale, kae fai mahala mo logo mai mua loa ko fakaaogā e taumatua ke fakalogo ki ai a tino katoa, tenā lā ko mea tāua 'kī o te fenua koa fakatahi i ai. I te fakatahiga penei, te fakaaliga o mahala mo muna o lātou mua koa gagalo ailoa, koa tukuifo o fāgai a kautama fou.

'Kaiga a te Fenua ki Uta i te Āhiga

A te vaega tenei e fakamatala he pō e tahi mai pō e uke kolā e olo ake tele i ai a te fenua ki uta i te āhiga. I te afa i he lua pō mai mua a he lukuga i uta i te āhiga, koa fai he tapatapaga i auala o te fa'kai o fakailoa atu te luaga (vaega o mea kai) e 'tau o avake e kāiga takitahi. Telā koa fakatagi i ai a te pū i te pogipogi o te pō o te fakaluaga, kae ke oko ake katoa ki uta i te 'kaiga i te tutonu. A taumatua o pouloto koa leva ni holoholo ake mo olotou makakafa. Ni tino o lātou e fili kolokolo, kae tino ake e fai a te ologou lāmi. Ū lā i te afa te sefulu tahi, kae koa holo ake i ai a fāfine mo kete me telē meakai. Kae tā te tutonu, koa tai tokouke hoki ailoa a tino i te āhiga. Koa tofu a pou mo taumatua, pelā hoki mo vahia pou koa nohoakigina katoa e pule o kāiga. A fāfine ko lātou ailoa e tafa ki tua i te pui o te āhiga, koa fakatoka nei a meakai a olotou tāgata.

Tā i ai te sefulu-lua, koa tū ake i ai a te tukumuna, fai ni ana mo muna fakafetai mō te oko ake o tino, kae

compete, and test." Probably the most important meanings stemming from the word are "to inspect" and "to display." During feasts it is common for community leaders to check that each family group has brought the specified foods (fakaluaga.) Several people go around to "check up" (āhi) on this and to announce, often humorously, if the requirement has been met. The other important meaning of the verb āhi is "display."

What is on display are the words, opinions, knowledge, and skill of each family's elders, the men who speak in the hall. The phrase, "house of words" is thus an appropriate description for Nanumea's āhiga, which is the "House of the Display of Words." This "House of Words" is the place where the most valued possessions of the community are protected, not things which can be seen with the eye, but the words handed down from those who have gone before, preserved here to feed the ongoing generations of the community, here in the House of Words. In the expression, "Display of Words," it is people who have been given food and drink in the form of words of the house. Additionally, in the Display of Words of the House, this is the time when one's hearing and understanding is tested, whether one understood the "Words of the House" in the past, is understanding them now, or will understand them in the future.

These words, which express the collective wisdom and instructions for the future generations of Nanumea, are an important part of the wealth of the community. When speeches are made, when knowledge from the past is called on by elders and offered for all to hear, valuable treasures of our community are being shared. In being publicly displayed and used, the wisdom of those who have gone before is also being transmitted through time to nourish the new generation.

Community Feasts in the Āhiga

This section describes a typical day in which the island gathers for a function in the āhiga. In the evening a day or two before a gathering, a crier goes up and down the village streets to announce the event and the food items each family is to bring. On the day of the feast, the trumpet (pu) signals to people that it is time to assemble for the noon meal. The elders who sit at the main posts would have already gone up with their materials for making kolokolo cord. Some of them would make cord, while others might play "Rummy." At about 11:30 women arrive with their baskets or trays of food. By noon, the āhiga would be full of people. At each post would sit a male elder and other male family heads would sit between the posts. The women would be back by the walls of the āhiga readying platters of food for their men.

At noon, the Speaker, tukumuna, stands, says a few words of thanks for people having gathered, and

fai kia fāfine ke hiki mai telē mo kete meakai a taumatua ki mua. Oti, toe fai ki te faifeau ke fai a te fakafetai ko te mea ailoa koa kamata o 'kai. A tamaliki fāfine e 'noho i tafa o olotou taumatua o fuefue lago. Kae e fakatalitali ke mākona a te pule o te kāiga, koa hiki i ai a tana laulau ki tua, kae koa toe foki mai mo te vai'fano mo te holo lima ke 'fano a lima o te taumatua.

Te 'Malu mo te Fakamataku o te Āhiga

Kae pelā mo fakamatalaga mai luga, e uke a faifaiga e fai ki uta i te āhiga. E luluku i ai a te fenua o tali mālō, fai pō fiafia, kae fai fātele mo tuisi hoki. E māhāni o i ai muna fakakatakata, mo tino e 'kata i te fale, kae tamaliki e luku fakatahi mo 'lou mātua ke tīia te fale. Kae i faifaiga i uta i te āhiga e i ai hoki he feitu fakatapuapu, me ko te tulaga 'malu o te nohoakiga o te fale e tāua 'kī.

E mafai o tai faka'kata a te lāuga, telā e mafai ai hoki a tino o 'kata. Kae ko te lahiga o lāuga ni lāuga e uiga ki mea mafa. E fakaaogā a taumatu 'lou lāuga mo fakatino mea kolā e aogā mō te fenua, telā lā e 'tau katoa mo tino o fakalogo'logo faka'lei. A tamaliki e 'tau o tausī faka'lei ke mo ā e gōgō tele i taimi e fai lāuga, kae pelā hoki mo tamatane 'vale e taumafai o olo ki loto i te fale, ko lātou e hē talia. Koa taofi tele e tino ke mō ā e tō ki loto. I pō mua e tai fakamataku o fakatupu he fakalavelave i loto i te fale.

I te 1963, kae koi tū i ai te āhiga mua, e i ai he mea ni tupu i ai. A te putukau tenei ko te Volenitia, atu lā e tai katoa lā he tino lua o lātou e faite olotou mea taulima i loto i te āhiga. Koa ulu mai a te tagata vale e tokotahi mo te fuafatu tai lahi e puke i tona lima. Hau ki luga ailoa i te tino telā e tafa atu ki a te ia mo ana muna penei: "A koe e toa?" Muna a te tino telā e noho i lalo: "A koe e valea. Fanatu lā o vale atu keātea mo mātou." Ko te mea ailoa koa magī ake a te leo: "Puke o tā!" 'Tu ake a tātoga o te Volenitia konei, ko te mea hoki ailoa koa haupapa a te lotou mea ki tapa. Ni ma'ligi loimata o te faifeau mo ana muna penei: "Koa uke a taimi ni lagona tele i ai e aku a vaega a tala konei. Kae tenei ni 'to pula oku mata ki ai, me ni tala tonu ailoa."

Koa 'Tau o Tavili i te Āhiga

I te lahiga o lukuga i uta i te āhiga, ko taumatua ailoa koa 'tau ai o tavili. E māhāni lātou o noho i mua kae fakapale ki te pou, me e noho i vahia a pou. I pō mua, taumatua penei e 'tau o koa oti ni lafo olotou mamafa me olotou katoa ki te fenua. Kae fai te pule o he kāiga koa katoa a tona 50 tauhaga, kao hē 'tau mo ia o noho a ia i te laina o toaina ki mua, kae ke noho ki tua mālie o taumatua, me ko ki tua i te puipuiga o te fale.

A tino mai tafa atu ia taumatua konei, e tai faigatā hoki ailoa mo ia o lāuga i te āhiga. Ke oko hoki kia te

asks the women to bring the trays of food for elders in the front. He then asks the pastor to say grace before everyone begins to eat. Young girls sit beside their family heads fanning away flies. When the family elder finishes, the girl carries his tray back to the rest of the family so they can eat, and brings handwashing water and a small towel to the elder so he can wash his hands.

Respect for the Āhiga

As we have seen above, there are many kinds of activities that take place in the āhiga. The community comes together in the building to greet visitors, to celebrate holidays and to hold fātele and other dances. Often there is joking and laughter, and children join parents in filling the hall. But there is a more serious side to āhiga etiquette, too, since respect for the āhiga is very important in Nanumea.

Even speeches which may be funny and provoke laughter usually have a serious side. Elders use their speeches to highlight what is important to the community, and everyone is expected to listen respectfully. Children are not allowed to make noise during speeches, and drunks, if they come around, are not tolerated. They are restrained by those nearby so that they cannot enter. In earlier days, it was dangerous to cause a disturbance in the āhiga.

In 1963, when Nanumea's old thatched āhiga was still standing, something like this happened. Members of the men's group called the Volentia, perhaps twenty men, were making handicrafts inside the āhiga when a drunken man entered with a large stone in his hand. He came up to the nearest person and said: "Do you want to fight?" The person sitting down answered: "Why don't you leave us alone and go away?" And at this, a shout rang out: "Beat him up!" The Volentia men stood up and began kicking the drunk. Tears spilling from his eyes, the pastor said: "Many times I have heard stories about this, but this is the first time I have witnessed it with my own eyes -- and the stories are really true."

Qualifications for Speaking in the Āhiga

Male elders are the only ones who are entitled to speak at most gatherings in the āhiga. Normally these men sit in the front, at the posts or in the gaps between them. In the past, all of these old men would have been expected to have donated a gift of produce of the land or sea to the community. If a family's oldest representative is only about 50 years old, he would not sit in line with the elders up front but rather a bit behind them, even as far back as the rear wall.

Anyone outside this relatively small group of elders feels unable to speak in the āhiga. The unwritten rule

ia telā koa oti ni kātoa a tona 50 tauhaga, koi tai faigatā hoki o lāuga, i te mea i faifaiga māhāni e tai tapu. I te manatu o taumatua, a lātou kolaa koi fo'liki, a te olotou mea e 'tau o fai ko te 'noho ailoa o fakalogo'logo kae o tauloto faka'lei ki te gahologa o lāuga, ke fakatali ailoa ki te taimi koa hinā me koa makalikali faka'lei i ai a olotou piho. Kolā ko iloga tonu ailoa o te toeaina. telā koa tai noho pelā ki te 60 tauhaga, kae koa mafai a ia o lāuga kae o fai hoki ana muna polopoloaki ki kautama mai lalo.

Nohoaga o te Āhiga

Ke pulapula nei ki te tulaga o nohoaga i te āhiga, i pō nei pelā hoki mo pō mua. Pelā mo tuhiga mai luga i te mata o muna tenie, ko tāgata mātua kolā e noho i ololou nohoanga fakapitoa mai mua i loto i te āhiga. A nohoaga konei e tuku ifo ki lalo i loto i te kāiga, mai tamana ki tana tama tagata. Taumatua ake e noho i te vahia o pou, kae ko kāiga o lātou katoa konei e nonoho mai tua o toeaina, pili ki te pui telā i tafa o pou. I te pō nei, a te aliki hopo e noho i te pou 'malu i te ngaloto o te fale i te feitu ki namo, kae i ona tafa koa noho te Tukumuna ki tona feitu fakaaatamai, mo te Pule Kaupule ki te feitu fakamāui.

Matagi o te Āhiga

Ko te matagi ni mafua i ai o galue'lue a launiu ke oko ki lau o lākau valevale, ko te afā (matagi malos) koa mafai ai o 'pa'ku a fale, kae 'ma'laga a tafito o lākau 'lahi. E pēnā hoki a te tagata. Ko te matagi o te loto e ana fakagalueluegina i ai a te tagata e uiga ki ana mea e fai, mai mea fo'liki ke oko ki mea 'lahi, ni mea 'lei ia me ni mea ma'hei.

E pelā mo muna konei koa fakaali mai, a te matagi he muna, mo he vaega fakamunaga, tāua i Nanumea. Te muna "matagi," e mafai o fakauiga ailoa ki te matagi telā e ili, kae e aumai te afā. Kae ko te fakaaogā fakafoofogina atu e fano ki amioga o tino, te lifu o latou: e māhāni tātou o fai me ko lātou koa "poko te matagi" kae fai koa lilifu 'ki i faifaiga e fai. Kae fai koa uhu he pehe, me koa mako he fātele kae koa kāmata o lagona te pā of the bokesi kae koa loto mālosi ki ai (atu lā koa tafuke ake o haka, kae kalaga ki luga, kae mata fiafia – e māneanea), ia, ko lātou konei koa oti ni "poko te matagi."

against speaking makes it difficult even for someone who has reached the age of 50 to speak. Elders say that those who are young should just listen properly and learn from the procession of speeches, waiting for the time that their hair is really white. That is the real identification of an elder, someone who is sixty or older. By that age, one is eligible to speak with authority and to discipline the younger generation.

Seating in the Āhiga

Let us now take a closer look at who sits where in the āhiga, both now and in the historic past. As noted above, male elders have always occupied prominent seats "in front," at the posts of the building. These seating places are inherited in the family, passing from father to son. Other elders occupy their family seating areas in the gaps between posts, while the families of each elder sit behind him near the low outer wall of the building. Today, the island's high chief sits at the center post on the lagoon side, flanked on his left by the speaker, tukumuna, and on his right by the council president, pulekaupule.

Wind of the Āhiga

Just as the wind moves the coconut leaves and other plants, and a strong wind can blow down houses and uproot big trees, so too with people. It is the wind of his heart that determines what a man does, from little things all the way to big things, either good things or bad.

As this saying shows, wind is an important concept in Nanumea. The word "wind," matagi, can refer simply to the wind that blows or brings storms. But the most interesting use of this word concerns people's enthusiasm: we say that they "catch the wind" (poko te matagi) when they are caught up in the excitement of the moment. If they are singing a song, or dancing a fātele and they begin to feel the beat and put their whole heart into it (maybe jumping up to dance individually with arms outspread and whooping enthusiastically, māneanea), they have "caught the wind."